Welcome Back!

The quarterly newsletter from MBFIA has lapsed in recent years. We plan to revivie this tradtion and stick to a quarterly schedule. This newsletter is scheduled for early April and you can expec to see the next one in early July as America celebrates the Semiquincentennial of the signing of the Declaration of Independence. In the October newsletter we will look forward to Heritage day. And to finish the year, the January 2027 newsletter will start the Centennial celebration of the McArthur-Burney Falls Memorial State Park.

8th Wonder of the World

SecretSanFrancisco.com recently posted an article about Burney Falls. Reprinted here by permission:

NEED TO GET PERMISSION

By Jamie Ferrell – Senior Staff Writer

February 28, 2026

Hidden In CA's 2nd-Oldest State Park, Flowing Year-Round, Lies A Waterfall That Roosevelt Once Called The '8th Wonder Of The World'

Burney Falls is the ultimate natural wonder in Shasta County, renowned for its massive scale and nearly constant flow of water.

I Bautista / Pexels

California's magnificent Burney Falls have long been celebrated for their beauty and year-round water flow. In fact, President Theodore Roosevelt supposedly called them the "eighth wonder of the world" during his visit in the early 20th century.

The towering waterfall is found in McArthur-Burney Falls Memorial State Park in Shasta County, the second-oldest state park in California. While it takes about 5 hours to reach Burney Falls by car from San Francisco, the route makes for a scenic road trip through some of the most beautiful parts of the state.

A perennial waterfall fed by underground springs

You only need to take a short hike for the best views of Burney Falls, which stretch 129 feet tall and nearly 300 feet wide. The water cascades over a mossy cliff draped with thousands of ferns, pouring not only from above but also straight through the rock face itself.

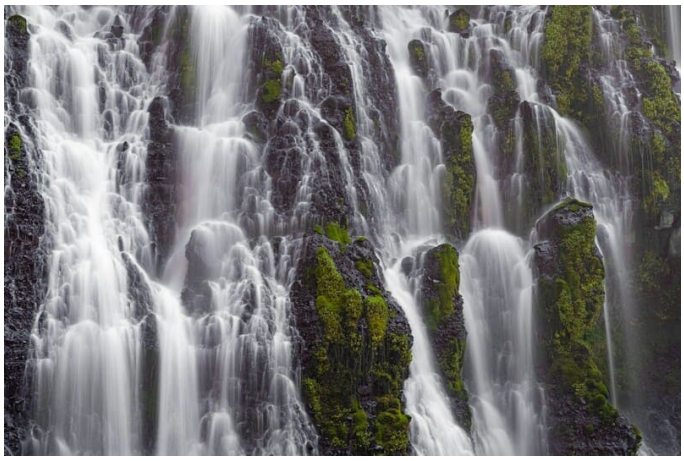
While most snowmelt-fed California waterfalls dry out seasonally, Burney Falls dumps about 100 million gallons of water every day, even in the driest summer months.

The area's unique geology creates a one-of-a-kind phenomenon, where the falls draw from underground springs in the volcanic basalt cliffs. This water source, combined with the surface water from Burney Creek, results in a powerful flow any time of year.

That said, peak season begins in April when snowmelt adds even more volume to the powerful cascade.

Most visitors can enjoy the view from the panoramic Burney Falls Overlook, which is located right next to the main parking lot. The overlook is accessible for most visitors, including those with mobility issues.

The 1.2-mile Falls Loop Trail leads visitors to the base of the falls and offers several more unique vantage points. Beat the crowds by arriving early or midweek.



Y S / Unsplash

McArthur-Burney Falls Memorial State Park features roughly five miles of hiking trails winding through evergreen forests, including a section of the renowned Pacific Crest Trail—perfect for adventurous hikers. The park also offers a campground and 24 rustic cabins for rent, along with a visitor center and general store. Nearby, Lake Britton provides a popular spot for fishing, swimming, or simply spending a few relaxing hours by the water.

This part of Northern California is also famous for more unique nature destinations that make for a memorable road trip. Lassen Volcanic National Park is just over an hour away, hiding a unique hydrothermal area available to visit in the summer fall. You could also check out the nearby 1,300-foot Subway Cave Lava Tube, or McCloud Falls in Shasta-Trinity National Forest.

About MBFIA & the Parks

The McArthur Burney Falls Interpretive Association (MBFIA) is an all-volunteer non-profit education organization that provides assistance and funding for activities which enhance the quality of visits to McArthur Burney Falls Memorial State Park, Castle Crags State Park and Ahjumawi Lava Springs State Park. The association was founded in 1984 to promote greater appreciation of the cultural and natural history of the region.

McArthur-Burney Falls Memorial State Park

The park is within the Cascade Range and Modoc Plateau natural region, with forest and five miles of streamside and lake shoreline, including a portion of Lake Britton.

The park's centerpiece is the 129-foot Burney Falls, which is not the highest or largest waterfall in the state, but possibly the most beautiful. Additional water comes from springs, joining to create a mist-filled basin. Burney Creek originates from the park's underground springs and flows to Lake Britton, getting larger along the way to the majestic falls.

The park's landscape was created by volcanic activity as well as erosion from weather and streams. This volcanic region is surrounded by mountain peaks and is covered by black volcanic rock, or basalt. Created over a million years ago, the layered, porous basalt retains rainwater and snow melt, which forms a large underground reservoir.

Within the park, the water emerges as springs at and above Burney Falls, where it flows at 100 million gallons every day.
Burney Falls was named after pioneer settler Samuel Burney who lived in the area in the 1850s. The McArthurs were pioneer settlers who arrived in the late 1800s. Descendants were responsible for saving the waterfall and nearby land from development. They bought the property and gave it to the state as a gift in the 1920s.

We experienced heavy snow in mid-February so the falls were flowing exeptionally heavy.

Figure 1: MBFIA President Jim Sacson with the heavily flowing falls, March 3, 2026

Visitor Information:

McArthur Burney Falls Memorial State Park entrance kiosk is closed in the off-season. Please bring exact change or credit/debit cards to pay by APM (Automatic Payment Machine) which is located just pass the entrance kiosk in front of the visitor center.

- Park Day-Use Fee - $10 Per Vehicle
- Overnight Camping - $35 Per Night (Includes One Vehicle).
- Additional Overnight Camping Vehicles - $10 Per night.

Castle Crags State Park

Figure 2: Courtesy of California State Parks, 2026.

Majestic Castle Crags have inspired enduring myths and legends. More than 170 million years old, these 6000-feet tall granite spires in the Castle Crags Wilderness border the northwestern edge of Castle Crags State Park.

Castle Crags State Park offers a variety of camping, picnicking, hiking, and fishing opportunities.

The park has 76 developed campsites that are each equipped with a picnic table, food locker, and a fire ring. Flush toilets, showers, and drinking water are available near each campsite. Picnic sites are located along the Sacramento River and at the awe-inspiring Vista Point.

With 28 miles of hiking trails, everyone can enjoy a mild stroll or an invigorating adventure. From the Vista Point parking area, a quarter mile accessible trail leads visitors to Vista Point where there are dramatic views of Castle Crags, Mount Shasta, and nearby Grays Rocks. Gentle and shaded, the mile long Root Creek Trail guides hikers along an accessible path to a year round flowing creek.

The most popular and challenging route is the Crags Trail which leads adventures to the base of Castle Dome where the views are simply breathtaking. The Pacific Crest Trail winds through the Park as well. Castle Crags State Park is often a respite for the weary hikers of this 2,650 mile trek from Mexico to Canada.

The Sacramento River flows through the park and has several access points that allow for fishing and hiking. Facilities at Riverside include camping and picnicking sites as well the famed pedestrian suspension bridge that crosses the Sacramento River.

Ahjumawi Lava Springs State Park

"Where the waters come together...." is a translation of the California Indian word Ahjumawi, which is also the self describing word used by the band of Pit River of Indians who still inhabit the area.
Ahjumawi is a place of exceptional, even primeval, beauty. Brilliant aqua bays and tree studded islets only a few yards long dot the shoreline of Ja-She Creek, Crystal Springs, and Horr Pond. Over two thirds of the area is covered by recent (three to five thousand years) lava flows including vast areas of jagged black basalt.
The park's backcountry is charactarized as wilderness with extremely rugged lava rock. Visitors should prepare adequately for their visit. While there are over twenty miles of park trails by which to explore this beautiful geographical wonder, please be advised that travel off the trails requires proper preparation and equipment. Be sure someone knows where you are going and when you expect to return.

Welcome

From State First District Assemblywoman Heather Hadwick

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Meet

The Newsletter Editor Tony Otto

I visited the falls and nearby Lassen park during summer vacation a couple of times as a primary grade schooler and as a junior high student. Those were great memories, along with coming around a curve on CA-299 and coming upon a VW Beetle sized boulder that had fallen on the upward lane of the highway. Fifty plus years later, the opportuntity to live in Fall River Mills came about. Now I live a few short miles from the falls. I was asked to join the Board of Directors of the MBFIA and I greatfully accepted. When the need to resume the quarterly newsletter arose, I willingly accepted the challenge.

Falls Visitors Center

The MBFIA operates the visitors center at the main parking lot above the falls. There you will find informative panels about the falls, the park, and the local flora & fauna. Several art exhibits are displayed in the center, including: Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit, sed do

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Visitor Center Store

At the center, these items are for sale:

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Featured Artist this Quarter: Suzy Monet

Photo & Headshot:

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Warnings for Falls Vistors:

McArthur Burney Falls State Park experiences extremely high visitation beginning in April and continuing through October. Most weekends all summer the park will fill to capacity and entrance into the park is subject to closure due to limited parking availability. Visitors should expect traffic delays on State Highway 89 for up to an hour prior to entering the park due to the increased visitation experienced at this park. It is illegal to park along Highway 89 outside of the park for a mile either direction. If you park along Highway 89 your vehicle will be subject to citation and tow. The speed limit is 55 mph along Highway 89 and utilized by a large volume of semitrucks, it is not recommended to walk along the highway. If you arrive to find the entrance closed due to full capacity, please return at a later time - typically after 4:00 p.m.

The park cannot admit entrance to vehicles over 32 feet for day-use or camping. Additionally, only a limited number of oversized vehicles (less than 32 feet in length) will be admitted into park. Oversized vehicles will only be allowed to park in the Lake Britton parking lot (approximately 1.5 miles walk to the falls) on Fridays, Saturdays, and Sundays.

Due to limited parking capacity, McArthur-Burney Falls Memorial State Park cannot accommodate entry, drop-offs or parking of tour busses until further notice.

Burney Falls General Store

Conveniently located within Burney Falls State Park, the Burney Falls General Store is your go-to stop for essential supplies and quick refreshments. Whether you're stocking up for a day hike, grabbing

snacks for the trail, or need last-minute camping supplies, the store has you covered. You'll find a variety of cold drinks, tasty treats, and basic camping necessities—all surrounded by the beauty of the park's towering pines and tranquil atmosphere. Friendly staff and a rustic setting make it a welcoming stop for campers and day visitors alike.

Job Openings

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MBFIA Information

Board Members

- President Jim Sacson
- Vice President: Mark Downie
- Secretary: Ann Sacson
- Treasurer Emiritus: Jaci White
- Webmaster: Bob Boyce
- Alice Hoveman
- Bill McSweeney
- Jill Overbaugh
- Tom Stockton
- Tony Otto

President's Message:

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Board Meeting Highlights - January to March 2026

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Questions Answered

Questions from the public on our website are answered by the Webmaster. Some of the more interesting answers for the previous quarter are:

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Memorial Tables

We are thrilled to offer you a limited opportunity to purchase an engraved memorial table to be placed in the Park for years to come!

Here's your opportunity to contribute a tax-deductible gift to the Park and to create an everlasting memory of a special time at the park or in honor of a family member or friend, while contributing to the Friends of the Falls at the same time! Contact Bill McSweeney at: calpacker@comcast.net or 415-726-3241 for information and an application!The MBFIA builds memorial tables and places them throughout the parks. They can be purchased for $2800. Each end can have memorial information etched into the bench.

Firewood Sales

The MFBIA has firewood at $99 per 21 pound bag available at Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet. The firewood is gathered consectetur adipiscing elit, sed do eiusmod tempor incididunt ut labore et dolore magna aliqua. Ut enim ad minim veniam, quis nostrud exercitation ullamco laboris nisi ut aliquip ex ea commodo consequat. Duis aute irure dolor in reprehenderit in voluptate velit esse cillum dolore eu fugiat nulla pariatur. Excepteur sint occaecat cupidatat non proident, sunt in culpa qui officia deserunt mollit anim id est laborum.

Friends of the Falls

Friends of Burney Falls provides education and interpretation and our programs highlight the Park's natural and cultural elements. Burney Falls offers hiking trails, flora and fauna, birds, squirrels and the like, camping, cabins and Lake Britton. Funds donated support Interpretive and educational activities, including guided hikes, Junior Ranger programs, campfire and craft activities, sing-alongs and group games. At Burney Falls, our Visitor Center includes a Gift Shop, as well as information about the geology, flora and fauna, cultural history and recreational opportunities in the park and the surrounding area. Our annual Heritage Day celebration in October offers weaving, cross-cut sawing, branding, candle-making, pine-doll making, apple cider pressing and Dutch Oven cooking. The Park has instituted a birding program, that includes guided bird identification walks, loaner binoculars plus a library of information. In addition, we have supported new native plants around the Visitor Center, with information about the plantings available for visitors.

We're also in the process of renewing our availability for sale and placement of memorial benches and picnic tables at the Park. Contact us for more details.

Upcoming Dates

- April 15 – Park opens for the season
- September 99 – Volunteer Lunch
- October 13 – Heritage Day Celebration

Donations

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We are a group of volunteers who love and support our northern California State Parks. We operate gift shops, sell firewood and do other fund-raisers to help us help the parks!

"The objectives of the Association are:

1. Promote the educational and interpretive activities of the State Park System, principally in McArthur Burney Falls Memorial State Park, Castle Crags State Park and Ahjumawi Lava Springs State Park through effective leadership and operation of the McArthur Burney Falls Interpretive Association.
2. Actively engage in fundraising activities to provide financial support for:
    1. Heritage Day
    2. Interpretive Staff and Programs
    3. Volunteer in Parks Program Support
    4. Visitor Center
    5. Other support expenses
3. Plan and co-manage all events and activities of the Annual Heritage Day Event with State Park personnel at no cost to the Intermountain Community and outside visitors.
4. Produce and make available to the park visitor, by sale or free distribution, suitable interpretive and educational literature, including books, maps, pamphlets, and DVD's.
5. Buy, sell, and distribute state-printed and other publications, which enhance visitor knowledge of the geologic history of Burney Falls, volcanic legacy of the Cascade Range and related topics (biodiversity of Northern California).
6. Acquire display materials or objects pertaining to the Cultural History and Natural History of the Intermountain area for the purpose of adding them to the interpretive collection in the Visitor Center.
7. Assist in the development and improvement of interpretive features, including signs, markers, and audio/visual stations, when aid is requested by the State Park system.

Contact Infomation

- McArthur-Burney Falls Memorial State Park, 24898 CA Hwy 89, Burney, CA 96013, (530) 335-2777
- Castle Crags State Park, 20022 Castle Creek Road, Castella, CA 96017, https://castlecragspark.org/
- MBFIA (McArthur-Burney Falls Interactive Association), PO Box 777, Burney 96013, friends@burneyfallspark.org
- Board President Jim Sacson: jimsacson@gmail.com, (530) 513-7102
- Burney Falls Visitor’s Center: (530) 555-1212
- Webmaster Bob Boyce: webmaster@burneyfallspark.org
- Newsletter Editor Tony Otto: tony.otto.frm@gmail.com, (530) 610-2133

On The Internet

- California State Parks: https://www.parks.ca.gov/
- MacArthur-Burney Memorial State Park:
  - https://www.parks.ca.gov/?page_id=455
  - https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/McArthur%E2%80%93Burney_Falls_Memorial_State_Park
  - https://www.facebook.com/mbfmsp/
  - https://www.tripadvisor.com/ShowUserReviews-g32125-d102684-r240734010-McArthur_Burney_Falls_Memorial_State_Park-Burney_California.html
  - https://www.reddit.com/r/norcalhiking/comments/1l2y6v9/mcarthur_burney_falls/
  - https://burneyfallshospitality.com/
- Castle Crags State Park:
  - https://www.parks.ca.gov/?page_id=454 https://castlecragspark.org/
  - https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Castle_Crags
  - https://wilderness.net/visit-wilderness/?ID=103
- Ahjumawi Lava Springs State Park:h
  - ttps://www.parks.ca.gov/?page_id=464
  - https://www.visitcalifornia.com/experience/ahjumawi-lava-springs-state-park/
  - https://www.shastacascade.com/account/ahjumawi-lava-springs-state-park
  - https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ahjumawi_Lava_Springs_State_Park
- MacArthur-Burney Falls Interpretive Association:
  - https://burneyfallspark.org/
- McArthur-Burney Falls General Store:
  - https://burneyfallshospitality.com/